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General Knowledge
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

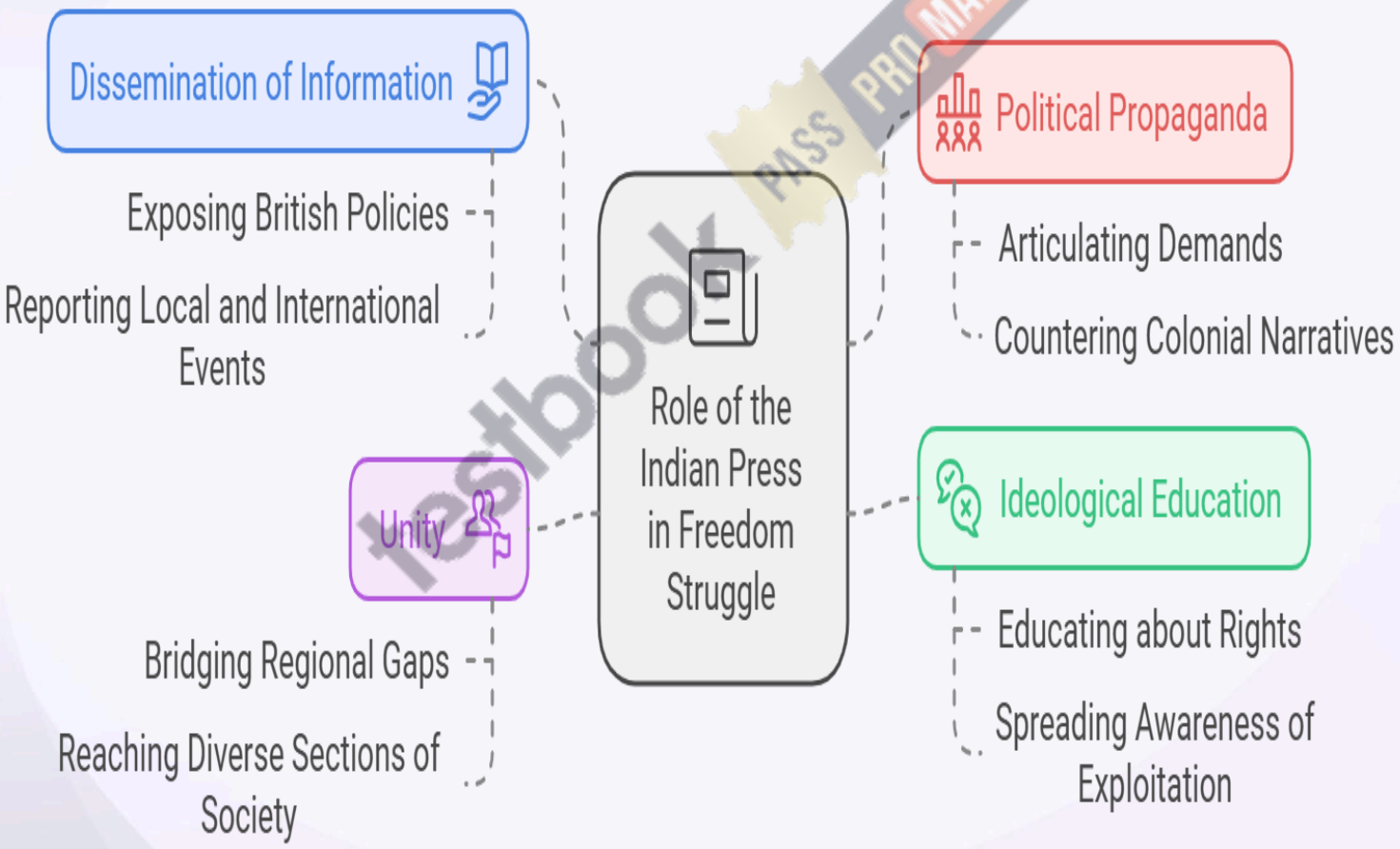
Newspapers, Magazines & Journals

Newspapers, Magazines, and Journals

Introduction

- The **press in India** emerged as a formidable force during the freedom struggle, playing a pivotal role in shaping the nationalist movement.
- At a time when **mass communication** tools were scarce, **newspapers** and **journals** became the primary medium for disseminating information, educating the masses, and fostering a sense of unity against **British colonial rule**.
- The Indian press not only served as a platform for exposing the oppressive policies of the British but also acted as a voice for the voiceless, giving a platform to the aspirations and grievances of the common people.
- The press acted as a tool for **political propaganda** and **ideological education**, laying the foundation for the awakening of national consciousness.
- **Nationalist leaders** recognized its potential early on and used it to articulate their demands, counter colonial narratives, and mobilize public opinion.
- Newspapers and journals in various languages, such as **Bengali**, **Hindi**, **Gujarati**, **Tamil**, **Marathi**, and **English**, reached diverse sections of society, bridging the gap between different regions and communities.
- During the early stages of the struggle, newspapers like the **Bengal Gazette**, **India Gazette**, and **Bombay Herald** focused on reporting local and international events.
- However, with the rise of social reformers like **Raja Ram Mohan Roy**, and later political figures like **Bal Gangadhar Tilak**, **Dadabhai Naoroji**, and **Mahatma Gandhi**, the press evolved into a dynamic medium for resistance.
- Journals such as **Sambad Kaumudi**, **Kesari**, and **Mahratta** became mouthpieces of reform and rebellion.
- Moreover, the press became a critical tool in:
    - Many newspapers uncovered the exploitative economic policies of the British, their mishandling of famines, and the widespread poverty in India.
    - With a nation divided by **language**, **caste**, and **religion**, the press played a crucial role in fostering a collective national identity.
    - The press educated Indians about their rights, **colonial exploitation**, and the broader principles of **freedom** and **self-rule**.
    - Journals like **Indian Sociologist** and **Bande Mataram**, published abroad, influenced global opinion and highlighted the Indian cause on the world stage.

- The British government, recognizing the threat posed by the press, introduced several restrictive laws, such as the **Vernacular Press Act of 1878** and the **Indian Press Act of 1910**, to curb its influence.
- Despite these restrictions, Indian newspapers and journals continued to flourish, adapting to censorship and using innovative strategies to spread their message.
- The Indian press was not just a medium of communication but a vital instrument of revolution.
- It catalyzed political awareness, inspired movements, and connected leaders with the masses. From the early efforts of James Augustus Hickey's **Bengal Gazette** to the revolutionary writings in **Kesari**, **Amrit Bazar Patrika** and **The Hindu**, the press remained steadfast in its mission to challenge colonial rule and inspire the fight for independence.

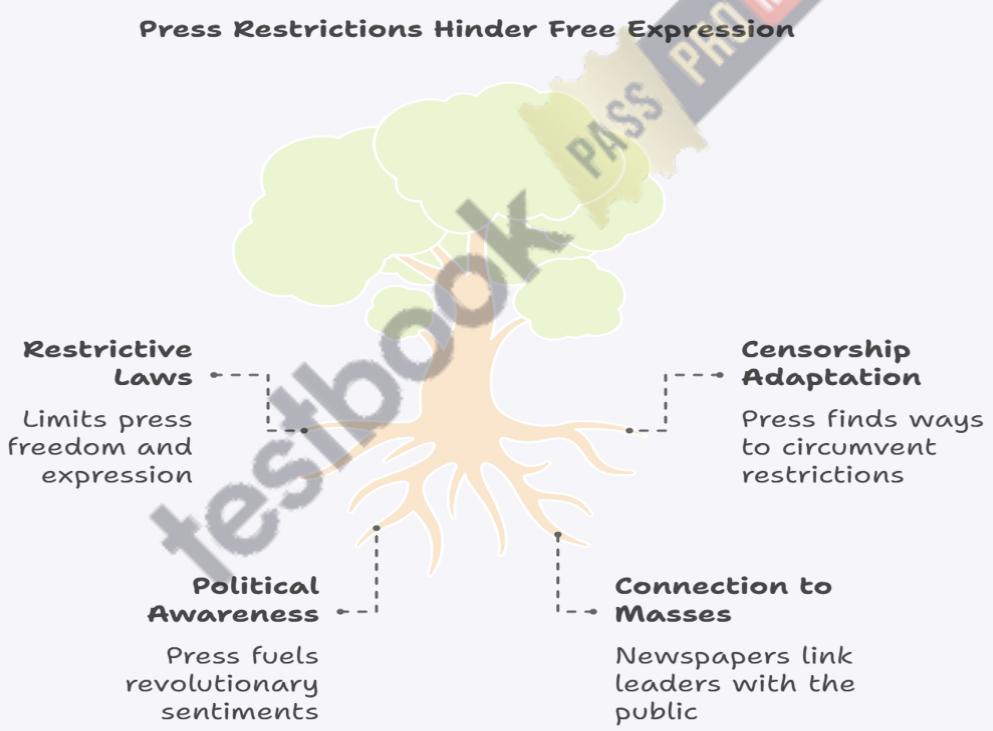


Key Newspapers and Journals

Name of Paper/Journal	Year & Place of Publication	Founder/Editor
Bengal Gazette	**1780, Calcutta**	James Augustus Hicky
India Gazette	**1787, Calcutta**	Associated with Henry Louis Vivian Derozio
Bombay Herald	**1789, Bombay**	—
Digdarshana	**1818, Calcutta**	—
Bengal Gazette (First Bengali Newspaper)	**1818, Calcutta**	Harishchandra Ray
Sambad Kaumudi (Weekly)	**1821, Calcutta**	Raja Ram Mohan Roy
Mirat-ul-Akbar (First Journal in Persian)	**1822, Calcutta**	Raja Ram Mohan Roy
Banga-Duta (Weekly in 4 languages)	**1822, Calcutta**	Raja Ram Mohan Roy and Dwarkanath Tagore
Bombay Times (Later The Times of India)	**1838, Bombay**	Founded by Thomas Bennett; and developed by Robert Knight
Rast Goftar (Gujarati Fortnightly)	**1851**	Dadabhai Naoroji
Hindu Patriot	**1853, Calcutta**	Girish Chandra Ghosh
Bengalee	**1862, Calcutta**	Girish Chandra Ghosh (Later S.N. Banerjea in 1879)

Amrit Bazar Patrika	**1868, Jessore**	Sisirkumar Ghosh and Motilal Ghosh
Bangadarshana (Bengali)	**1873, Calcutta**	Bankimchandra Chatterji
Indian Statesman (Later The Statesman)	**1875, Calcutta**	Started by Robert Knight
The Hindu (English Weekly)	**1878, Madras**	G.S. Aiyar, Viraraghavachari, Subha Rao Pandit
Tribune (Daily)	**1881, Lahore**	Dayal Singh Majeetia
Kesari (Marathi Daily) and Maharatta (English Weekly)	**1881, Bombay**	Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Chiplunkar, Agarkar
Swadesamitran (Tamil)	**1882, Madras**	G.S. Aiyar
Paridasak (Weekly)	**1886**	Bipin Chandra Pal
Yugantar	**1906, Bengal**	Barindra Kumar Ghosh and Bhupendra Dutta
Indian Sociologist	**Published in London**	Shyamji Krishna Varma
Bande Mataram	**Published in Paris**	Madam Bhikaji Cama
Talwar	**Published in Berlin**	Virendranath Chattopadhyay
Ghadar	**1913, Vancouver**	Ghadar Party
Bombay Chronicle	**1913, Bombay**	Pherozeshah Mehta
The Hindustan Times	**1920, Delhi**	Founded by K.M. Panikkar

Leader (English)	**—**	Madan Mohan Malaviya
Bahishkrit Bharat (Marathi Fortnightly)	**1927**	B.R. Ambedkar
Kudi Arasu (Tamil)	**1910**	E.V. Ramaswamy Naicker (Periyar)
Bandi Jivan	**Bengal**	Sachindranath Sanyal
National Herald	**1938**	Jawaharlal Nehru

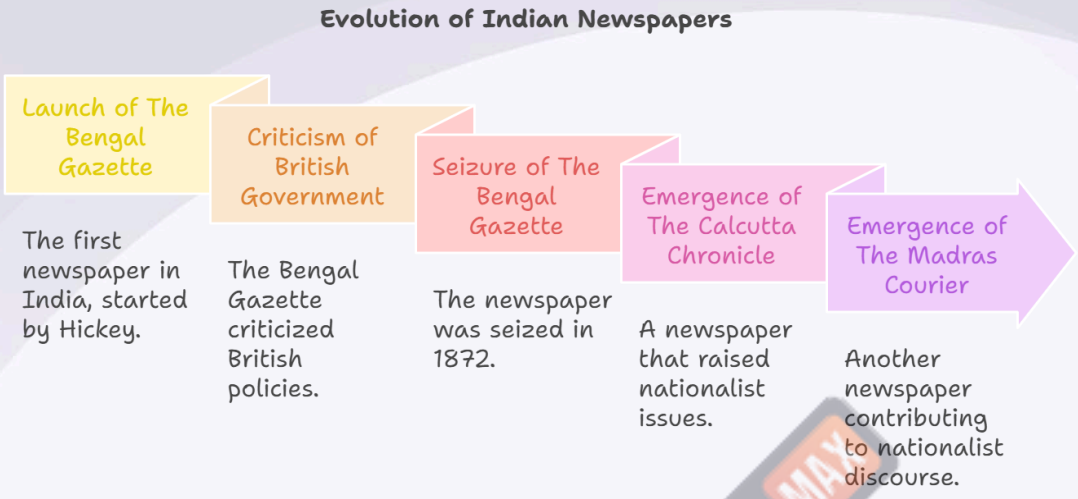


Role of the Press in the Freedom Struggle

Development of Press in India

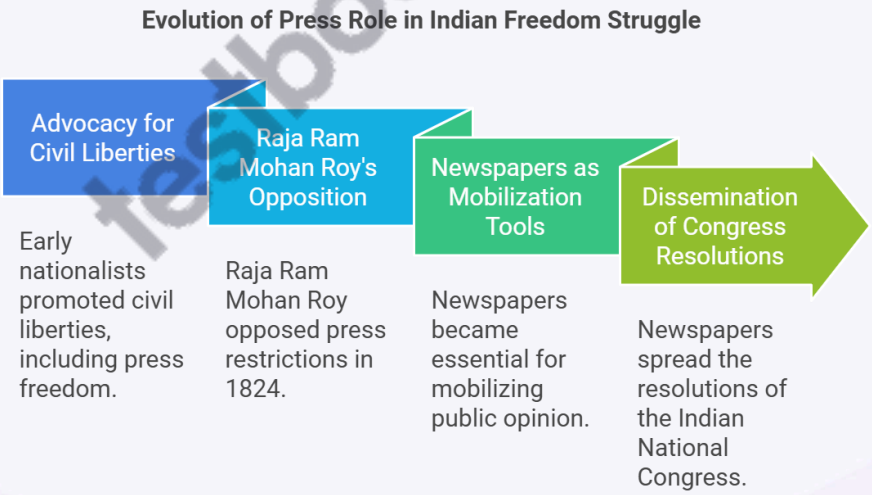
- The first newspaper in India, **The Bengal Gazette**, was started in **1780** by **James Augustus Hickey**. It criticized the British government and was eventually seized in **1872**.

- Several newspapers such as **The Calcutta Chronicle** and **The Madras Courier** followed, raising nationalist concerns.



Struggles for Press Freedom

- Early nationalists advocated civil liberties, including press freedom. Raja Ram Mohan Roy opposed press restrictions as early as 1824.
- Newspapers became critical tools for mobilizing public opinion and disseminating the resolutions of organizations like the Indian National Congress.



Notable Press Laws and Acts

- **Censorship of Press Act, 1799:**
  - Enacted by Lord Wellesley to curb French influence and impose pre-censorship during wartime.

- **Licensing Regulations, 1823:**
    - John Adams imposed these regulations, making it illegal to operate a press without a license.
- Resulted in the closure of Raja Ram Mohan Roy's Mirat-ul-Akbar.

Press Act of 1835 (Metcalfe Act):

- Repealed the 1823 ordinance; which required publishers to provide details of publication premises.
- **Licensing Act, 1857:**
    - Passed during the 1857 Revolt; reintroduced licensing restrictions.
- **Vernacular Press Act, 1878:**
    - Nicknamed "Gagging Act."
    - Aimed to suppress vernacular newspapers critical of the British.
    - Empowered district magistrates to demand bonds from publishers and seize press equipment.

Newspaper (Incitement to Offences) Act, 1908:

- Targeted extremist nationalist activities.
- Allowed confiscation of press property for incitement to violence.

Indian Press Act, 1910:

- Revived the harsh measures of the Vernacular Press Act.
- Allowed government control over publication and confiscation of material deemed objectionable.

Contributions of Key Newspapers

- **Kesari and Maharatta:** Used by Bal Gangadhar Tilak for stirring nationalist sentiment.
- **The Hindu:** Played a critical role in spreading awareness of Congress resolutions.
- **Amrita Bazar Patrika:** Fearlessly criticized British policies.
- **Indian Sociologist:** Aimed to garner international support for India's independence.

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